

All Broken Up About It

WHILE THINGS ARE looking up for the office softball team — our centerfielder promised to remember to bring his glove this weekend — that isn't to say hope springs eternal on every diamond.

And speaking of stones, a few have been cast lately in the direction of the University of Texas at El Paso baseball program. Life for the Miners, it seems, isn't what it used to be. Or what the players feel it should be.

One of their number called yours truly here the other day to alert us to the fact that paper plates get better treatment than Miner baseball players are getting.

"Every bat we have is broken and the balls we're using are all taped," said the voice. "And now we've been told we won't get to play all our games at Dudley Field."

Our first reaction was to ask the guy what soap opera script he was reading from. I mean, although the Miners don't deserve the same fringe benefits the Cincinnati Reds have coming, they would seem to be entitled to the same breaks as what little league teams get. Surely, a team that



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will be asked later on in the season to "play ball" against the likes of Arizona State and Arizona deserves a little in the way of equipment.

As we were to discover, however, the sad story is a true story, at least in part. The bats are broken, all right. The balls are taped and Dudley Field won't be theirs to have and to hold this season. But it's not as if the athletic department is trying to be mean to the baseball players the way Lucy is to Charlie Brown.

It's a fact that money is creating more problems for the Miners than any curve ball pitcher they've ever faced. Turning UTEP into a national powerhouse in college baseball isn't a priority because the climate isn't right. The financial climate, that is.

IF IT WERE just weather they had to worry about, there would be no problem. And, that's why a lot of us who major in the seventh-inning stretch don't understand it when the Miners struggle every year just to break even what when this could easily be a baseball hotbed. That's why they don't understand it when the Miners can't find a relief pitcher to keep Arizona State from beating them 20-0.

But there isn't a lot of noggin power behind that kind of thinking. UTEP isn't Arizona State in baseball because it can't afford to be. The Miners do get all the scholarships (13) coming to them that the NCAA allows but that's where the similarities end.

Hopefully, the Miner baseball team
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